

# Lanthanum

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Following its discovery, it took almost 100 years to figure out how to make a pure sample of this lanthanide. Pure lanthanum is used to make clear camera lenses, and some compounds of lanthanum are used when refining the liquid fuel petroleum.

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**ATOMIC MASS** 138.905

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**STATE** Solid

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**DISCOVERY** 1839 (Carl Gustav Mosander)

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Mischmetal (an alloy of lanthanum, cerium, and praseodymium) is used to produce sparks for special effects in films.

*Lanthanum will quickly tarnish when it is exposed to air.*

**Laboratory  
sample of  
pure lanthanum**

